3.3 The Columbian Exchange

One of the best parts about traveling to different places is encountering new and unusual foods, plants, and animals. Beginning in the 1500s, European explorers and colonists encountered and introduced hundreds of new and amazing things.

MAIN IDEA The Columbian Exchange was a significant biological event that changed societies and environments around the world.

TWO WORLDS CONNECT

Millions of years ago, the landmasses of North and South America were connected to Eurasia and Africa. Over time, they drifted far apart and an ocean filled the gap between them. The two hemispheres developed in isolation from each other, resulting in distinct plants and animals evolving in each half of the world. Farmers in the two hemispheres developed and planted different crops and raised different livestock.

The European encounter with the Americas coincided with improved methods of sea travel and the desire to explore and conquer new lands. The combined impact was enormous. Places and people that were once isolated from one another became part of a global exchange network. The contact and trade between these far-flung lands helped some people—and harmed others.

When Europeans crossed the Atlantic in 1492, they carried more than just their ideas—they also brought plants and animals. As they prepared to sail home, they packed new plants and animals they found in the Americas to introduce to the people of Europe. This period of biological mixing between the New World of the Americas and the Old World of Europe, Africa, and Asia is known as the **Columbian Exchange**—named after Christopher Columbus. This momentous swap of biological matter had major economic and social effects in the Americas, both good and bad.

Some of the species the Europeans introduced to the Americas caused significant environmental changes. For example, the Spanish transported livestock, including cattle, horses, sheep, and goats, to the Americas. These animals' roaming and grazing habits altered native landscapes. Europeans also slashed and burned forests to clear lands for farming.

Additionally, Europeans introduced deadly new diseases to the Western Hemisphere. Because they had already encountered diseases such as smallpox, Europeans had developed an **immunity**, or a natural protection, to those diseases. They could even carry the diseases without showing symptoms or appearing sick.

Native Americans had not been exposed to European diseases, so they did not have immunity to them. Epidemics of smallpox, influenza, measles, and other diseases spread quickly after Europeans arrived in the Americas. Between 1519 and 1565, the native population of Central America fell from about 25 million to 2.5 million due to disease alone. Within three centuries of Columbus's landing, about 90 percent of the Native American population had died of disease.

CHANGES FOR THE BETTER

Not all of the consequences of the Columbian Exchange were so negative, however. The great transatlantic swap introduced positive things to both sides. Europeans imported pigs, chickens, and other domesticated animals and brought horses with them, which Native Americans incorporated into their cultures. Europeans also introduced new crops to the Americas. Wheat, barley, rye, rice, and cotton were some of the plants introduced to the Western Hemisphere.

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Other crops included bananas, coffee beans, and sugarcane, all of which grew especially well in Central and South America.

The Western Hemisphere also contributed an important medicine called **quinine** to Europe, Africa, and Asia. Europeans learned about quinine, which comes from the bark of a tree in South America, in the 1600s. For about 300 years, it served as the only effective remedy for malaria, which is carried by mosquitoes. Quinine's use as a treatment for malaria benefited millions of people, but it allowed Europeans to later colonize malaria-ridden areas of the world.

The Columbian Exchange affected the lives of people throughout the world. Some changes were positive, such as improved nutrition because of a greater variety of foods. However, the effect of the Columbian Exchange on native populations in the Americas was disastrous.

More Options, New Troubles

The exchange of crops and animals increased agricultural options and enriched diets on the continents of Europe, North America, Africa, and South America. Some elements of the exchange, such as tobacco and a host of European diseases, were not as positive.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why was the Columbian Exchange such an important phenomenon in world history?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Based on what you notice on the map, what foods do you enjoy today that originated in the Americas?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Which hemisphere benefited most from the Columbian Exchange and why?

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